ERA 22

The Conservative Resurgence

1980 – 1991

Reagan · the New Right · Reaganomics · the end of the Cold War

ESSENTIAL QUESTION

How did conservatism reshape America—and how did the Cold War finally end?

KEY TERMS

The New Right · Reaganomics · the 'evil empire' · Gorbachev · the fall of the Berlin Wall

ALIGNED TO

CED Topic 9.2–9.3 · AMSCO Ch. 9.2–9.3

A TURN TO THE RIGHT

The Conservative Resurgence

Reagan & the New Right



- In 1980, **Ronald Reagan** swept to power on a wave of **conservatism**.
- The **New Right** united economic conservatives and religious voters.
- The **Moral Majority** mobilized evangelicals into a political force.

The Reagan Revolution

I

Reaganomics

Supply-side tax cuts and deregulation to spur growth.

II

Smaller Government

Cut domestic programs—while defense spending soared.

III

Culture Wars

Championed **traditional values** in fights over abortion, religion, and family.

The Great Communicator

- A former actor, Reagan mastered television and the public mood.
- His optimism—'Morning in America'—restored national confidence.
- He reshaped the political center for a generation.



SECTION

The End of the Cold War

From 'Evil Empire' to Summit



- Reagan branded the USSR an '**evil empire**' and launched a huge arms buildup.
- Soviet leader **Gorbachev** pursued reform—**glasnost** and **perestroika**.
- The two signed the **INF Treaty**, slashing nuclear arms.

The Fall of the Berlin Wall

- In 1989, the **Berlin Wall** fell as Eastern Europe threw off communism.
- In 1991, the **Soviet Union** itself dissolved.
- The Cold War was over—and the U.S. stood as the world's **sole superpower**.



KEY TAKEAWAYS

The Conservative Resurgence

1. **Reagan** and the **New Right** reshaped politics around **Reaganomics**, smaller government, and traditional values.
2. A massive arms buildup and **Gorbachev's** reforms combined to thaw the Cold War.
3. The fall of the **Berlin Wall** and collapse of the **Soviet Union** left the U.S. the world's **sole superpower**.

DISCUSS & APPLY

The Conservative Resurgence

AP HISTORICAL REASONING PRACTICE

CAUSATION

Explain the rise of the **New Right** and the appeal of **Reaganomics**.

COMPARISON

Compare **Reagan's** and earlier presidents' approaches to the role of **government**.

CAUSATION

Explain the factors that brought about the **end of the Cold War**.

Up next — **Class 63: The Post–Cold War World** (the 1990s & the digital age)